

UNIVERSITY OF ILLINOIS SYSTEM

Board of Trustees

Illinois Reimagined:

A Strategic Proposal for Lifelong Learning, Civic Renewal, and Civilizational Impact

Submitted to the Strategic Planning Steering Committee

March 2026 — DRAFT FOR REVIEW

***"The role of a great university is not to mirror the world as it is, but to help
build the world as it should be."***

Executive Summary

The University of Illinois System stands at a civilizational inflection point. The institutions, economic models, and governance structures that have shaped modern society are producing outcomes — runaway inequality, ecological crisis, democratic fragility, and technology optimized for extraction — that threaten the future its own graduates will inhabit. This is not a peripheral concern. It is the central challenge the University must now address.

This proposal calls on the Board of Trustees to authorize a fundamental reorientation of the University's mission, structure, and strategy around four interdependent commitments:

- Lifelong Learning as Infrastructure — expanding from a one-time credential event to an ongoing service for every Illinoisan, powered by a statewide library network
- Discovery Oriented Toward Regeneration — research that challenges exploitative models rather than serving them, measured in civilizational impact, not grant cycles
- Public Engagement as Democracy — embedding the University in communities as a collaborator, not an authority, with communities first and companies second
- Economic Development for Shared Flourishing — building regional ecosystems and community wealth rather than recruiting extractive corporate tenants

Underpinning all four is a values reordering — Planet before People before Profit — and the urgent deployment of AI not as a displacement engine but as a personalization and emancipation tool. Time is not on our side. The window to act is measured in years, not decades.

The Case for Urgency: Why This Cannot Wait

Higher education is not facing a slow evolution. It is facing a disruption that, if unaddressed, will render the traditional university model as obsolete as the industrial economy it was built to serve. Three forces are converging simultaneously and with compounding speed.

1. The Legitimacy Crisis

The cost of a university degree has outpaced inflation for four consecutive decades, while wage premiums have compressed and student debt has become a generational anchor. Prospective students — and their families — are asking a rational question: Is this worth it? Without a compelling, differentiated answer that is grounded in demonstrated community value rather than institutional prestige, enrollment will continue to erode. Illinois cannot recruit or retain its way out of a mission problem.

2. The AI Displacement Wave

The most powerful cognitive technology in human history is being deployed primarily to displace and concentrate wealth — not because its designers are malicious, but because the values embedded in their education have never seriously challenged that direction. Universities trained those engineers. The critical question is whether Illinois will train the next generation differently: with the ethical spine, humanistic depth, and systems thinking required to build technology that serves human dignity. If not, Illinois becomes part of the problem it was chartered to solve.

3. The Civilizational Stakes

The de-emphasis of the humanities over the past three decades was not a neutral budget decision. It was a civilizational error. The humanities teach human beings how to be human with one another — how to reason ethically, empathize across difference, question power, and imagine alternatives. Strip that foundation out of professional and technical education, and you produce exactly what we have now: systems of extraordinary capability organized around extractive and sociopathic goals. Illinois has the scale, the talent, and the public trust to course-correct. But institutional resistance to change — more than any budget constraint — is now the greatest threat the University faces.

The University has a last-mover disadvantage it cannot afford. The window to lead this transformation is open now — and it will not stay open.

Guiding Principles

This proposal is organized around four pillars drawn from the intellectual tradition of Sir Ken Robinson, systems science, and the ethical imperatives of our historical moment. They are not aspirational statements. They are design constraints — every strategic decision should be evaluated against them.

The Values Hierarchy

 Planet First Every institutional decision—research, partnerships, curriculum, operations—is evaluated against its impact on ecological and civilizational health.	 People Second Human dignity, wellbeing, and emancipation guide who we serve, how we serve them, and which communities receive priority investment.	 Profit as Enabler Financial sustainability is the means, not the mission. Revenue decisions serve the two priorities above—not the other way around.
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From Standardization to Human Flourishing

Sir Ken Robinson spent his life arguing that our education system was designed for a world that no longer exists — built to produce compliant workers, not creative, adaptable, purposeful human beings. Illinois should lead the answer to the question Robinson left us: What would a system look like that was actually designed around human flourishing? That means centering curiosity over compliance, honoring divergent thinking, and recognizing that intelligence is diverse, dynamic, and deeply personal.

From Short-Term Cycles to Generational Strategy

Universities operate on annual budget cycles and five-year plans while the challenges they are preparing students to solve — climate disruption, democratic erosion, technological displacement — unfold over generations. Illinois must build a strategy the way forests grow: with patient investment in deep roots, not just visible branches. That means funding research programs whose ROI may take twenty years to materialize, and measuring success not in placement rates but in whether graduates are contributing meaningfully to the world a decade out.

From Symbolic to Structural Inclusion

Collaboration and inclusivity must be structurally rewarded, not just rhetorically celebrated. Tenure and promotion systems that reward individual publication over interdisciplinary teamwork produce faculty incentivized to compete rather than co-create. Illinois should pioneer evaluation frameworks that recognize collaborative scholarship, team-taught courses, and community-embedded research as first-class academic contributions.

AI as Emancipation, Not Extraction

AI, used wisely, enables, for the first time at scale, meeting each learner where they are, adapting to how they think, and helping each person build toward their own version of excellence. Illinois should deploy AI-augmented learning environments not to replace human educators, but to free them from rote tasks so they can do what only humans can do: inspire, mentor, challenge, and connect.

Strategic Pillars

Pillar 1: Lifelong Learning as Statewide Infrastructure

Illinois should fundamentally reframe education as a lifelong public service, not a one-time credential event. The majority of Illinoisans leave formal education and never return — yet the complexity of the challenges they face accelerates every year. The University has the infrastructure to change this.

The centerpiece of this pillar is a Statewide Knowledge Network connecting every public library in Illinois into a living, AI-augmented learning ecosystem. Libraries are trusted civic anchors in communities that universities rarely reach. Making them nodes in the University's knowledge infrastructure transforms Illinois into the first state in which every resident — regardless of zip code, income, or credentials — has access to world-class learning resources.

- Connect all Illinois public libraries into a unified digital and in-person learning network
- Deploy AI-powered personalized learning pathways accessible at every library terminal
- Develop modular, stackable credentials usable at any life stage — not four-year-or-nothing pathways
- Establish regional Learning Hubs co-designed with communities, not delivered to them
- Reward faculty engagement with this network on equal footing with traditional publication

Pillar 2: Research Oriented Toward Civilizational Renewal

Illinois should reorient its research mission around civilization's actual urgent problems — not just what is currently fundable. That means explicitly prioritizing research that challenges exploitative economic and governance models rather than serving them, and measuring impact over generations rather than grant cycles.

- Establish a Center for Regenerative Systems — a cross-disciplinary institute focused on post-extractive economic, ecological, and governance models
- Require ethical impact assessment for all major research partnerships, with Planet > People > Profit as the governing framework
- Create structural incentives for interdisciplinary collaboration — reformed tenure metrics, team grants, and co-authorship recognition
- Build AI research governance frameworks that center human dignity before those frameworks are made irrelevant by deployment speed
- Reinstate the humanities as the ethical spine of STEM education — not as electives but as core requirements

Pillar 3: Public Engagement as Democracy in Practice

Illinois should close the gap between institutional knowledge and the communities that need it most — embedding researchers and students in civic life not as experts delivering answers, but as collaborators listening first. Public engagement should be structurally rewarded the same as publication.

- Build the statewide library network with communities first and companies second
- Establish Community Co-Design Labs in underserved regions — research and problem-solving partnerships anchored in neighborhood priorities
- Use AI to democratize access — translating complex research into tools that a grandmother in Carbondale or a laid-off worker in Rockford can actually use
- Prioritize historically excluded and economically stressed communities in resource allocation, not as an afterthought but as a first principle
- Measure public engagement success in community resilience over time — not in events held or websites visited

Pillar 4: Economic Development for Shared and Durable Flourishing

Illinois should challenge the assumption that economic development means attracting corporations and growing GDP. Those are instruments, not destinations. The University should be building an economy worthy of its people and its land — one measured in wellbeing, resilience, and regenerative capacity.

- Prioritize regional ecosystem development over trophy corporate announcements
- Invest in community wealth-building: cooperatives, anchor institution procurement, and locally-rooted entrepreneurship
- Extend AI-powered business tools and workforce learning to small businesses and entrepreneurs in underserved communities
- Position the statewide library network as economic development infrastructure — not just learning infrastructure
- Serve as connective tissue between municipalities, anchoring collaborative rather than competitive regional development

Value Proposition for Alumni — Past, Current, and Future

Past Alumni: Reconnection and Relevance

Hundreds of thousands of Illinois alumni carry the University's brand but have no ongoing relationship with its mission. This proposal creates a structured pathway for re-engagement that delivers real value — not just fundraising asks.

- Lifetime Learning Access: all alumni receive access to the Statewide Knowledge Network at no cost
- Alumni Innovation Network: structured peer collaboration forums across industries and geographies
- Mentorship Infrastructure: AI-matched mentorship connecting experienced alumni with current students and mid-career re-learners
- Impact Investing Pathway: alumni investment vehicles channeling capital toward the University's regenerative research and community development initiatives

Current Students: Education for the World That Is Coming

Current students are the generation that will navigate the compounding crises described in this proposal. Their education must prepare them not just for first jobs, but for the full complexity of a civilization in transition.

- Every degree program integrates humanities, ethics, and systems thinking as core — not elective — requirements
- AI augmentation tools personalize learning and free educators for mentorship and deeper engagement
- Community-embedded research experiences replace or supplement traditional internships for all students
- Stackable credentials allow students to build portfolios of expertise across disciplines throughout their lives

Future Alumni: A University Worthy of Their Investment

Future students and their families are asking whether a University of Illinois degree is worth the investment of time, money, and years of their lives. This proposal gives them a clear and differentiated answer: Illinois prepares you not just for a career but for a life of purpose, impact, and continuous growth — and it stays with you for life.

Implementation Roadmap with Milestones

The following phased roadmap is organized around urgency. Phase 0 launches within months, not years. Institutional resistance is the greatest threat to this plan's success — the committee's mandate must include the authority to move at transformation speed.

PHASE 0 Months 0 – 6

Foundation

Building the structure that makes everything else possible

OBJECTIVE	KEY RESULTS	VALUE DELIVERED
- Establish Board-level transformation authority - Ratify Planet > People > Profit as governing values - Map every community & library partnership statewide	- Transformation Office lives within 60 days 20+ advisory council members seated - Full statewide asset map complete - Values charter ratified by Trustees	- Internal alignment across all campuses - Stakeholder confidence signal to investors - Community trust-building begins
MILESTONE Governance structure operational		

PHASE 1 Months 6 – 18

Launch

Pilots live. Communities connected. Alumni re-engaged.

OBJECTIVE	KEY RESULTS	VALUE DELIVERED
- Pilot the Statewide Library Learning Network in 3 regions - Re-engage alumni as lifelong learners and co-investors - Embed University in underserved communities	3 regional library pilots live (urban, suburban, rural) 5 Community Co-Design Labs operational 1,000+ alumni in lifelong learning pathways - First regenerative research cohort funded	- Demonstrable community reach beyond campus - Alumni re-engagement baseline established - National media & investor confidence
MILESTONE Network pilots proven & funded		

PHASE 2 Months 18 – 36

Scale*Statewide. Systemic. Structurally transformative.*

OBJECTIVE	KEY RESULTS	VALUE DELIVERED
- Expand library network to every corner of Illinois - Launch Center for Regenerative Systems - Embed humanities & ethics in every degree program	- Full statewide library network is live 50,000+ Illinoisans in active learning - AI governance is active across all research partnerships - Community wealth initiative in 10 regions	- Equity impact visible statewide - Illinois was named a national model - Alumni giving has significantly increased
MILESTONE Illinois named national model for public university mission		

PHASE 3 Years 3 – 5

Lead*Illinois becomes the defining public university of the 21st century*

OBJECTIVE	KEY RESULTS	VALUE DELIVERED
- Establish Illinois as the preeminent 21st-century public university - Build endowment independent of corporate funding cycles - Publish annual Civilizational Impact Report	100,000+ Illinoisans in lifelong learning - Model replicated by peer institutions nationally - Measurable resilience gains in all pilot communities - Alumni giving & engagement at decade-high levels	- Generational brand transformation complete - Durable investor & stakeholder confidence - A university built for human flourishing
MILESTONE Generational brand transformation complete		

The Case for Stakeholders and Investors

This proposal is not a values exercise. It is a strategic repositioning in response to real market, demographic, and civilizational forces — and it presents a compelling investment thesis for stakeholders who understand what is actually coming.

Why This Is the Right Bet

- Demographic reality: Illinois's population is aging and diversifying. Lifelong learning is not an idealistic add-on — it is the growth market for higher education in the next thirty years.
- Talent differentiation: employers increasingly require graduates who can think ethically, collaborate across differences, and navigate complex systems. Illinois will produce that talent when its peers cannot.
- AI positioning: institutions that deploy AI for human augmentation—not displacement—will earn public trust and regulatory goodwill that AI-maximalist competitors are rapidly eroding.
- Community anchor advantage: Universities embedded in community ecosystems are more resilient to disruption than those that rely on enrollment cycles and fluctuations in federal grant funding.
- Alumni lifetime value: a university that serves its alumni for life — not just four years — generates compounding engagement, giving, and advocacy that transforms its financial trajectory.

What We Are Asking Stakeholders to Support

We are asking stakeholders and investors to support a University that is willing to say clearly: our purpose is to help build a world worthy of human dignity. We believe that is both the right thing and the smart thing — and that these are no longer separable propositions.

Specific investment vehicles will be developed in Phase 0, including impact-aligned alumni investment funds, philanthropic partnerships for the Center for Regenerative Systems, and corporate partnerships explicitly structured around the Planet > People > Profit framework.

***The question is not whether Illinois can afford to make this transformation.
The question is whether Illinois can afford not to.***

Conclusion: A University Worthy of Its Public Trust

The University of Illinois was built on a simple, radical idea: that the benefits of higher learning should not be reserved for the privileged few. That idea is now in crisis — threatened not by external forces alone, but by decades of institutional drift toward exclusivity, corporate alignment, and short-term thinking.

This proposal is an invitation to reclaim the founding promise. Not sentimentally. Urgently. With a roadmap, a values framework, and a clear-eyed assessment of what is at stake if we do not move — and move now.

The world is not heading in the right direction. The inequities are compounding. The technology is not waiting. And the people most harmed by the current trajectory are precisely those the University of Illinois was chartered to serve.

There is still time. Not much. But enough — if the Board of Trustees chooses, today, to lead.

Illinois Reimagined: Not a twenty-year plan. A decision made today.

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